“Depression and anxiety are always caused by sin.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that every emotional struggle comes from unconfessed sin or lack of faith. Well-meaning friends who asked, “What are you doing wrong?” when you were hurting. Not knowing that the body, the brain, life events, and loss all affect mood. Shame that made you hide your struggles. Times when a sin did make things worse, so you assumed it always must be the cause.

What Scripture teaches

Sin can contribute to emotional pain, but Scripture does not teach that it is always the cause. When the disciples asked whose sin made a man blind, Jesus said neither. Elijah, a faithful prophet, became so exhausted and discouraged that he asked to die, and God responded with rest, food, and gentle care. Paul despaired even of life. Depression and anxiety can come from many sources: body, brain, loss, stress, trauma, thinking patterns, and spiritual struggles. God meets you in all of them.

> *“And His disciples asked Him, ‘Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?’ Jesus answered, ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.’”* **(John 9:2–3)**.

Also see

> “While he himself traveled on a day’s journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. ‘I have had enough, LORD,’ he said. ‘Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.’” **(1 Kings 19:4)**.

> “We do not want you to be unaware, brothers, of the hardships we encountered in the province of Asia. We were under a burden far beyond our ability to endure, so that we despaired even of life. Indeed, we felt we were under the sentence of death, in order that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God, who raises the dead” **(2 Corinthians 1:8–9)**.

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” **(Psalm 34:18)**.

> “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds” **(Psalm 147:3)**.

Common self-statements

- If I weren’t sinning, I wouldn’t be depressed.
- My anxiety proves I don’t trust God.
- I must have done something to deserve this.
- God is punishing me with these feelings.
- If I confess enough, this will go away.
- Christians who are depressed aren’t right with God.

Common logical errors

- **Overgeneralization:** Turning “sin can cause distress” into “all distress is caused by sin.”
- **Personalization:** Blaming yourself for something with many causes.
- **Jumping to conclusions:** Deciding the cause without considering the body, stress, or loss.
- **Mental filter:** Ignoring Bible heroes who struggled deeply without sinning as the cause.

- **Shame-based thinking:** Treating a painful condition as proof of moral failure.

Challenging questions

- What did Jesus say when the disciples blamed sin for the man's blindness?
- Was Elijah's despair caused by sin, or by exhaustion and fear?
- Did God scold Elijah, or did He feed him and let him sleep?
- What other causes could be affecting my mood: sleep, health, stress, loss?
- Have I confessed and repented and still feel this way? What might that tell me?
- Would I say this to a friend who was depressed?
- Who first taught me that emotional pain always means sin?

Truth summary

> Depression and anxiety are not always caused by sin. They can come from my body, my brain, loss, stress, my thinking, or many other things. Faithful people in the Bible felt deep despair. God is near to the brokenhearted, and He meets me with care, not condemnation. I can seek His help and every good help He provides.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Depression, Symptoms of
- Anxiety/Worry
- Hopeless
- Sickness
- Therapy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Sin

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Depression and anxiety are always caused by sin"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Depression and anxiety are always caused by sin." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did Jesus say about whose sin caused the blindness?
- ☐ Was Elijah's despair caused by sin or exhaustion?
- ☐ How did God treat Elijah?
- ☐ What else could be affecting my mood?
- ☐ Would I say this to a hurting friend?
- ☐ Who taught me this belief?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not all emotional pain is caused by sin.
- ☐ God is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ God meets me with care, not condemnation.
- ☐ Faithful people in the Bible felt deep despair too.
- ☐ I can look for every cause and every kind of help.
- ☐ God heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **John 9:2–3**
  "And His disciples asked Him, 'Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?' Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"
- [ ] **1 Kings 19:4**
  "While he himself traveled on a day's journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. 'I have had enough, LORD,' he said. 'Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.'"
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 1:8–9**
  "We do not want you to be unaware, brothers, of the hardships we encountered in the province of Asia. We were under a burden far beyond our ability to endure, so that we despaired even of life. Indeed, we felt we were under the sentence of death, in order that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God, who raises the dead."
- [ ] **Psalm 34:18**
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- [ ] **Psalm 147:3**
  "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Mood and life log:** Each day, rate my mood from 0 to 10 and note sleep, food, stress, and activity. Look for patterns at the end of the week.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 34:18 becomes: "The LORD is near to **Sarah** when **she** is brokenhearted; He saves **her** when **she** is contrite in spirit."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Depression, Symptoms of" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read 1 Kings 19:1–18,** and list every way God cared for Elijah before He spoke to him about his mission.
- ☐ **Schedule a checkup with your doctor** and mention how your mood has been.
- ☐ **For three days, get regular sleep, meals, and a short walk,** then rate your mood again.
- ☐ **Talk with a pastor or Christian counselor** who understands depression and anxiety.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Depression and anxiety are always caused by sin": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Mood 0–10 and one possible cause
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Depression and anxiety are always caused by sin.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, thank You that You are near to the brokenhearted. Help me reject the lie that depression and anxiety are always caused by sin. Show me the true causes of my pain, lead me to the help I need, and let me feel Your care instead of condemnation. Heal my heart and bind up my wounds. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.